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Grover Mitchell

The current Count Basie Orchestra is under the able leadership of trombonist Grover Mitchell. Grover first joined the Basie band in November of 1962 and led the trombone section for important years during the 60s and 70s. He has also performed with the great big bands of Duke Ellington and Lionel Hampton, and appears on many recordings with all of these ensembles. In Basie's later years, Grover became an important companion and confidante for the Count. As he himself puts it, "I grew into this job."

Grover Mitchell was interviewed by Monk Rowe after a performance of the Basie Orchestra at the Sarasota Jazz Festival on April 13, 1996.

MR: We are filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. My name is Monk Rowe, and we're honored to have with us a man who has had a huge part in the two greatest jazz orchestras, welcome Grover Mitchell.

GM: Oh, thank you. Thanks for having me.

MR: Can you possibly describe to me that tempo that you did "Jumpin' at the Woodside" to end that concert?

GM: Fast.

MR: Fast. Off the metronome.

GM: Oh, yeah. Yeah it's a, you know that's one of the success factors about this band is our ability to handle the extremely fast and the extremely slow, if you can remember "L'il Darling" and those things, how slow we played those things.

MR: It's almost a tradition with the Basie band to be able to generate excitement and swing but so soft and slow.

GM: Oh, yeah. That's a lesson that, well this band is kind of an apprenticeship for somebody like me. I've been in and out of this band for about 35 years, in one capacity or another. Most of my time I spent as lead trombone player. Then I came back in 1980 when the old man got sick, and I was helping. I was playing, but at the same time, you know I was starting to be his hands and arms and legs and I had to even help him think you know. Because he'd had a couple of strokes and all that, and he could get a little bit, you know that dementia that goes along with older people having strokes and everything. So it wasn't, to me that I did so much for him but I learned so much having to behave like that with him, because he was a great man. You know? You'd have to be around him to really see, you know he was a great man. Yeah. He was a naturally great man.

MR: I should explain to our viewers that you have taken over the Basie band, it's about eight months now?

GM: About nine. Yeah. It's getting on towards a year.

MR: Well they seem to be in good hands.

GM: Well thank you. I appreciate that.

MR: When did you realize that maybe you could make a living as a trombone player?

GM: Well I started playing trombone when I was 13 years old and I was too dumb to understand what it really took to be a professional musician. If I had known I probably would have, if I'd had that much brains I would have quit. But it's a very difficult profession. And as you go along you find out that most of the people in the profession really shouldn't be in it, because it is really difficult. I mean, let me re-phrase that. I shouldn't say shouldn't be in it. But it, to be what you expect of us, in this particular level, is very difficult. And so many people don't quite reach it. And they want to and they try and you know it's not about that, and they work and they work and they work, but if I had known the requirements, I would have probably had better sense.

MR: From not just a talent standpoint but from other aspects too?

GM: Well everything kind of pushes into it. You know what I mean? There's a lot of people that really want to do well in music, but it's just not their thing. They really want, you know it's glamorous and music is fun, let's face it. It's a lot of work you know, and we go through a lot of pain on the one side, but music is fun. There's great camaraderie, and then when you really like to play and you're around a bunch of guys that can really play, they bring, you know, they bring further, you seem to improve just around this kind of talent. And it's great. But there's some people that get involved and they really frustrate themselves. And they don't really get up to the line. I'm not maligning anybody in particular but I'm just saying after being out there 40 years like I have been, well if I tell the truth it'd be 50. I've seen a lot of people come and go, and in other words, you start to understand what the requirements are. And it could be awesome. I mean there are lesser bands I mean that — in which lesser people thrive fairly well. But this thing is scary when you get into it and when you finally make it, and you say what did I get myself into?

MR: It seems like a fine line too between being pretty good and getting to that next level. And when you've got a whole band like you do of excellence, you can really tell.

GM: Well thank you. And you've said it better than I did what I was trying to say. Yeah. You feel good when you can survive amongst this level people. You really go on and say wow, you know a few pinches and it's me, I did it, I'm doing it. You know what I mean?

MR: Well when I went out the stage door earlier and I saw your bus, it's a pretty good looking bus — how has being on the road changed, 1995 from years ago?

GM: The jet plane. You can close New York and open Stockholm, you know what I mean? You can leave Paducah, Kentucky and play a one-nighter in L.A. The jet plane has really put another dimension into this thing. We do great distances and in short amounts of

time. It's not unusual to leave New York at 8:00 in the evening and the next evening you're going on stage in London or Moscow or Paris. So the jet plane has really, you know has really — and that's international, but this huge country, you know how you can't appreciate how big the United States is until you do go outside the United States. Because the distance from New York to San Francisco is about the same as from New York to London or Paris. And so it's just as difficult to go from New York to San Francisco as it is to go from New York to London but then when you start thinking in terms that you're going to another country and another continent, you know, it sounds further but the distances in the United States itself are great. I did today, I got up at 4:00 in the morning in New York and did a one-nighter here in Sarasota this evening.

MR: Well you've had a longer day than I thought.

GM: Oh, yeah, it's been long.

MR: The Basie groups that you played with had some marvelous players, and some of the best I think ensembles that he had. Who were your favorite bandmates?

GM: Well we had some genius-level people you know. This was — Ellington's band and Basie's band, the one thing that caused them in some way to be at the ability level that we were able to maintain was we, in the older days and prior to 1964, we couldn't get jobs in studios you know. We couldn't play at the networks and all that. And so Ellington and Basie had access to the greatest black musicians alive. In other words, that's what we had to aspire to. And you couldn't think of going to NBC or ABC or be in a Hollywood studio. Which later I did, you know, and quite successfully. But in those days they had access to the greatest black musicians available. The greatest. And so they had their choice. That's something.

MR: That's a really important statement. I haven't heard it put quite that way.

GM: I know, most people won't say it. They're afraid to say it. But I know it. Because we would sit there and our greatest competition was each other because we, you know, until Clark Terry and those guys in 1964 and '63 started getting into the networks and all that kind of stuff. There was a couple of guys here and there you know; CBS was pretty good, they had a guy over there. And a New York contractor named Lou Shoobe, he was quite fair, and so some guys got jobs. But for the most part you couldn't even dream of getting a studio job, it was just unheard of in those days.

MR: Was there problems in different parts of the country going into —

GM: Well there was problems everywhere in the country you know. They pointed a finger at the south and all this, the south was so obvious you know what I mean? But the same problems existed everywhere. Now you've got to realize that the centers of media was New York and Chicago and Los Angeles you know. There's nothing south about any of those, you know what I mean. But socially you know this country has been very strange

in that sense I mean? To be kind, you know. It just got off to a bad start, and we still suffer from that. You see, black people came out of slavery. And slavery was an ugly institution. And the general population had to excuse slavery for themselves by saying that we were these terrible, inferior people. And this has been passed on and on and on. And I mean they had to tell themselves they were doing us a favor, to put you into bondage. And that was a big deal. And a lot of that is still here. You know we just finally got to the place where guys could play quarterback on professional football teams, and they had themselves talked into this thing saying that they couldn't play these so-called intelligence positions, you know which is crazy. The most awesome things you'll ever come into as a human being is the human mind. I don't care what kind of man it is, you know, what color or what nationality, it's an awesome thing. And we're all equally stupid and equally smart.

MR: It seems to take too long.

GM: Oh, yeah, it continues to be a problem. It's convenient for some people and the thing is the separation has caused people not to think of you, you know what I mean, not to think of you? In other words, because people are separated from one another, for instance if you were with one group and if you were in a power group or something like that, I don't care how much you might think of me, you would have to reach outside your group to think of me. I mean it's not that you are a bad person, but this process of thinking of me would be very difficult for you. So that's what really happens. We're not thought into the process. We're never thought into the process. The one thing that was ever planned for us in this country was slavery. And everything else has been a huge battle I mean to prove that you could do something other than this you know. And even now, you almost have to make this great effort. You still hear people say oh the first black guy to manage a baseball team, the first black guy to play in a symphony. This is 1996, you know, and they're still at this place. And that's because of the structure of society. Everybody's not mean. Everybody's not mean about this. And there's some people, I mean I'm speaking from the point of view of a pretty well experienced 66-year-old man, some people want to be your friend, but they don't have enough nerve. They've got so much pressure from the outside, you know I mean you can almost see them waving from the crowd saying well you're a pretty good guy but I can't do it. That's just the way it is. It has to change. The world's too small.

MR: What do you make of the fact that festivals like this one, when the audience seems to be almost totally white?

GM: Well again we're back to this social structure and the social division and then you've got to figure that most black people are poor and they can't afford it. That's a fact. And the funny thing about it is, we're talking about jazz came out of the black community, but the

people that don't know anything about jazz are the first ones to say I never heard of Count Basie or Charlie Parker is a black person. You know? Somehow or other they're — it's the media structure and the huge warehousing in these areas and neighborhoods and all that kind of stuff, it creates dumb stuff.

MR: Well you've been a part of some of the greatest music making and what was it like playing with Duke?

GM: Oh, no, it was great. He was something else man, he was really bright. You know he was a special case. You know I'd have to sit here a week to tell you about Duke Ellington. I could tell you a lot about Basie but Duke was great. He was great. He was great, now we've got another one, Quincy Jones, but these guys were great at pulling people together and pulling talent together and making things happen you know? These guys can really see this little tiny thing in one guy and they'd really magnify it and all of a sudden you might, under somebody else's handling you would never hear of that side of maybe some particular artist. Like Quincy. He's out there on the West Coast, he'll make an album or something like that, and he'll hear some specific guy that you would never think of, and he'll fly him all the way from New York to L.A. to, maybe like Al Grey, you know, just to play one solo on one track. But when the thing gets together, nobody stops to think of how he amalgamated all of these individuals and these little things. You know they hear the album as a whole, but he's a thinker. And Duke was like that.

MR: He knew what every person could do and what their strong point was.

GM: Exactly. And he just blended them into this Ellington-oleo.

MR: I heard he had his own method of discipline. Or, lack of—

GM: Look, let me tell you. I was in that band one time and just to give you I guess we'll call it an anecdote. The first night, I lived in the San Francisco area. We had left the Monterey Jazz Festival. The Monterey Jazz Festival, this was the second year, 1960 I guess it was. And we got to San Francisco in this club that we played in that was owned by the DuPonts called The Nevey. And the first night was just absolutely gorgeous. The band just roared. This was my first night with these people, see? And the second night, it seemed like everybody was late. There was a nucleus in this band that was always on time. You could always figure you would see Lawrence Brown, you know he was very dapper and he was sitting there and never late and all that stuff. And oh, Lou [inaudible] the trumpet player there, and the rhythm section pretty much would be there. And so some of the guys were out milling around in the audience and I mean here I am in what was my hometown then, trying to make this big impression and you know I was really embarrassed you know what I mean? So he had this funny old medley or something that he could play with two or three guys on the stand, and he would go through this act, you know, "Ladies and Gentlemen, we've been successful over the years" and he'd go into

these unison type things with maybe six people up there. So I told him I says, "wow, Duke, man this is terrible, this is embarrassing, all of my friends are here." And he says, "look, I don't worry about these people. Number one, these people are not going to drive me crazy. I live for the night that this band is great. Tonight means nothing to me." I said, "oh, how can you say that?" Because here are these guys milling around, and Jimmy Hamilton was sitting there, he was playing and I'm all upset, and I said, "Jimmy, look at all these people walking around out here, and we should be up on the bandstand playing" you know and he looks at me like I'm crazy and the waiter comes up to the bandstand and says, "Mr. Hamilton, your steak is ready." And right in the middle of the tune he steps over the rail and starts cutting on a steak. And so about a week later we were playing at an Air Force Base outside of Sacramento called Mather Air Force Base. Now there's no place to go. So here's the band, and they've got to play. There's no place for these guys to fool around and you know, this whole military atmosphere, and so the band is just roaring, beautiful. And so I hear the piano player, Duke, saying dink-dink-dink-dink; dink-dink-dink-dink. And so I looked around, and he over there and he says, [whispers] "see what I mean?" So. That's the way he was. And nothing bothered him. But you couldn't do that with Basie. Nothing bothered him. You walked into Basie's band late, and you walked up on that bandstand, and you know the very fastest solo possible, you're cold, you're going to play right then. He had all kinds of ways, all kinds of ways of punishing you, you know what I mean? Awful. Jesus, he was just mean. Or some tight solo you know darn well you can't play, you know, because you haven't warmed up, or some high ballad or something, and you've got to play it right there on the spot. He didn't say anything.

MR: He didn't bawl you out.

GM: Yeah. You're messing it up you know, and he's sitting over there. And if you say anything he'd say, "well that's your job, that's your solo."

MR: Lot to be learned from that.

GM: That's right. Oh he was something else. He was great though.

MR: I really loved hearing the chunk-chunk of that acoustic guitar today.

GM: Oh, Freddie, oh, yeah. He added so much character to that band, he really — you know we still try, we have a very good guitarist whom we've only had for about, well eight or nine months, and we're pretty close to getting back to that feel. Because you know we've got a bunch of people now you know that play guitar, they usually learn to play electric guitar, solid body guitars that you can't even hear unless them amplify them through — but this kid is really good. But Freddie, he really, really had this particular sound, this metronomic ability to play good time. And he was special.

MR: I've always wondered how were the solos spread around in the Basie band?

GM: Well everything was kind of not on purpose. He just kind of, you just kind of grew — in other words, you have a character, do you play?

MR: Yes.

GM: If you have a character about you, you either can play something really pretty or you can play something really fast, and some of these things you know you can do better than others. And these guys, they can figure this out. And you are usually going to be playing something that you're pretty strong at. You know I was a pretty high player and I had a pretty tone, so I was always expected to play the ballads. In fact, he never let me play jazz, and I wanted to be hot, and you know he says, "no, no, no, no, no, no" he would always say, "you're a trombonist, not a trombone player. I want you to be a trombonist." And I was, you know I wanted to roar. But you know then I played lead and you know did my little Tommy Dorsey act. But you know as I look back, you know, it was a career-saving thing because when you do have some facet of your style or whatever it is magnified, and in these bands the whole world hears you.

MR: Basie had a way of tailoring arrangements to feature his sound?

GM: Yeah. What he did, a good example of that was "L'il Darling." When Neal brought "L'il Darling" in it was supposed to be fast. Did you know that?

MR: No I didn't.

GM: [scats]. And Basie says, "it's a nice song but it's terrible," and he slowed it way back [scats]. And there was a couple of more he did that way. And he could do just the opposite with something that was maybe would play faster. He was very good at tempo. Now you see he came through that Vaudeville school you know with the dancers and all that kind of stuff, and he had really good insight. A lot of that sparse piano style of his came from accompanying dancers. If you could remember how piano players used to accompany tap dancers. So you see what I mean, it was just a removal from that, and taking advantage of this real sparse musical type of thing with the band. If you could imagine a piano player that had to accompany tap dancers, Basie was a perfect example of that. That's how that little plink here and a plink there got to be part of, well to a great degree it got to be part of what he was doing. He was a Vaudevillian.

MR: That must have been quite an experience for an arranger to work on something and keep hearing this — here's how it goes in my head — to come in and he'd say, "no, not like that."

GM: That's right. And turn it totally into something else. Marshall Royal was pretty good at that too you know. Marshall was very bright and he was a very fine lead alto player, very gruff but he was a genius. Very gruff. A beautiful sound, and it was just one of the most natural musicians I ever encountered.

MR: They call it "Straw Boss."

GM: Yeah, well we called him the "Field Marshall" and the "Burgermeister." That was his whole attitude and everything. But he could back it up. Yeah. He was great.

MR: Everybody seemed to get nicknames along the way.

GM: Oh, yeah. We still do that.

MR: Yeah? What's yours?

GM: I'm not going to tell you.

MR: Okay. Fair enough. My goodness. And Joe comes together with the band a few times a year, right?

GM: You notice how natural it is when he does come in? Oh, no, no, no, Joe was a very, very big part of the comeback of this band. You know the big band business had really frittered down pretty well in the 50s, and Joe was a huge, huge factor in the resurgence of this band. I would be remiss to tell you differently. And the old man never forgot that and he was always very, you know, appreciative of the fact of how important Joe was to that stage of the career. And Joe is another genius-level vocalist. You can't lose him, he's, you know, I think he could do grand opera as well as what you see us doing here. A natural singer. Like Sarah Vaughan was the same way. I think Joe could do "Pagliacci" just as well as he can do the blues.

MR: I almost heard that in the "Here's To Life" tonight.

GM: Oh, yeah, no, he's a vocalist. Oh, he is a musician. And he has a great ear, you can't lose him. He can sing the slowest tempo, and the fastest thing. You know he's very —

MR: When you pick from your book of arrangements, how many charts do you usually work out of?

GM: Well we carry about 300 with us. And I try to make things flow. You know what I mean? I try to mix a certain amount of things that people want to hear and you know that it's like standard repertoire, you know they want to hear "April in Paris" and "L'il Darling," "One O'Clock Jump," "Corner Pocket." So you have to, I try to blend them into a combination of good arrangements that works within the framework of what this band is all about and at the same time to keep the musicians interested and from getting them bored. And trying to do a service too — splitting the difference between the audience and something very interesting, something swinging, and you have to keep these, these are very, very bright people and you have to keep them interested. You know how children are who are very bright in school and if you aren't careful they lose interest? Well that's the way these people are. You have to challenge them all the time. If you start just playing the same old easy things every night and just making the job, you're going to get in big trouble. And you're going to get a lot of yawning, and a lot of lack of concentration. So I'm trying to make it flow you know. I make mistakes you know. I make mistakes, it doesn't always come off. But I've been lucky.

MR: Do you enjoy being the leader?

GM: Yes. I got to the place where I just figured I was the leader. I didn't want to do anything else. I had my own band after I left this band. And I feel that I grew into this role. I know that might sound a little bit — I don't want it to sound arrogant but I didn't want to be a sideman anymore. I figured that what I was able to do now, my contribution would be better as a leader. I think I know what I'm doing, and I think my long apprenticeship has pretty well prepared me for this.

MR: I'll drink to that.

GM: Thank you.

MR: Where is the band heading tomorrow?

GM: Across state. We're going to around Orlando and then we're going up into Georgia and then we're going to go up into the Carolinas and into Hilton Head. Same old stuff. Same old bus. But let me tell you, I still enjoy it. It's still fun. As long as the music is good and the guys can play, it can really be fun. Sometimes I get so tired I say to myself what the hell am I still doing this for? But you go out and some kid will just burn right through some great solo, and there's your answer right there.

MR: Just like Duke said.

GM: Yeah. That's it. He was something boy, that Duke Ellington was really something.

MR: Going overseas anytime soon?

GM: Yeah. We will probably spend the whole month of July in Japan. And before that we've got some jazz festival in Denmark we're going to play, and there's some talk that we're going to go to St. Petersburg, Russia for one day. Because we do things like that. We do. We went to Russia, oh, six months ago, and we stayed there a week and played three days. So we're always — and last year, in 1995, we spent most of the year out of the country. France, Spain, Portugal, Italy. Yeah.

MR: Everybody knows the Basie band, around the world?

GM: Yeah well it's a funny thing. Americans are pretty blasé music-wise and entertainment wise, you know they've got everything. But we can walk down the street in some European capitals and especially in Asian places, and kids can know who you are, recognize you on the street. Japan. Thailand. And it was like that in Sweden and Germany and England, but they're getting very Americanized, I mean they're getting very blasé too. But they still are more interested in this thing, you know Americans are just beginning to understand that, or to look into jazz as the very serious music that it is. Like Duke Ellington used to say, jazz is the most serious music you can ever get involved in. And Europeans always gave us that respect. To them it was a serious act that you were in. You were a serious artist. And to Americans, well you were kind of a clown you know. And it was, you know they never equated us or looked at us as people on the

concert stage. They always kind of visualized you in the smoky club and all that kind of stuff. And you were just kind of a character of the evening. But we're deadly serious, well trained, highly experienced musicians — artists. And like Duke says, there's no musician more serious than a jazz musician, or has to do more work. It's very difficult you know in terms of the spontaneity that's required.

MR: Well put. And I know you have to get up and get on that bus in the morning.

GM: Yes. Early.

MR: This has been absolutely fascinating. And I can't wait for our students to listen to some of these things.

GM: Well I hope I said something that makes some kind of sense or that's interesting to somebody you know. And I thank you for having me. I really enjoyed this interview.

MR: Well I'm pleased you were able to come. On behalf of Hamilton College, I'd like to thank Grover Mitchell for joining us. It's been a great pleasure.

GM: And it's been a pleasure for me.